

A STUDY OF
INTERACTIONAL
PATTERNS,
PATHOLOGIES,
AND PARADOXES

PRAGMATICS
OF HUMAN
COMMUNICATION

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A Study of Interactional Patterns,
Pathologies, and Paradoxes

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Chapter 2

Some Tentative Axioms of Communication

2.1

Introduction

The conclusions reached in the first chapter generally emphasized the inapplicability of many traditional psychiatric notions to our proposed framework and so may seem to leave very little on which the study of the pragmatics of human communication could be based. We want to show next that this is not so. However, to do this, we have to start with some simple properties of communication that have fundamental interpersonal implications. It will be seen that these properties are in the nature of axioms within our hypothetical calculus of human communication. When these have been defined we will be in a position to consider some of their possible pathologies in Chapter 3.

2.2

The Impossibility of Not Communicating

2.21

First of all, there is a property of behavior that could hardly be more basic and is, therefore, often overlooked: behavior has no opposite. In other words, there is no such thing as nonbehavior or, to put it even more simply: one cannot *not* behave. Now, if it is accepted that all behavior in an interactional situation ¹ has message

¹ It might be added that, even alone, it is possible to have dialogues in fantasy, with one's hallucinations (15), or with life (s. 8.3). Perhaps such internal "communication" follows some of the same rules which govern interpersonal com-

value, i.e., is communication, it follows that no matter how one may try, one cannot *not* communicate. Activity or inactivity, words or silence all have message value: they influence others and these others, in turn, cannot *not* respond to these communications and are thus themselves communicating. It should be clearly understood that the mere absence of talking or of taking notice of each other is no exception to what has just been asserted. The man at a crowded lunch counter who looks straight ahead, or the airplane passenger who sits with his eyes closed, are both communicating that they do not want to speak to anybody or be spoken to, and their neighbors usually "get the message" and respond appropriately by leaving them alone. This, obviously, is just as much an interchange of communication as an animated discussion.²

Neither can we say that "communication" only takes place when it is intentional, conscious, or successful, that is, when mutual understanding occurs. Whether message sent equals message received is an important but different order of analysis, as it must rest ultimately on evaluations of specific, introspective, subject-reported data, which we choose to neglect for the exposition of a behavioral-theory of communication. On the question of misunderstanding, our concern, given certain formal properties of communication, is

munication; such unobservable phenomena, however, are outside the scope of our meaning of the term.

²Very interesting research in this field has been carried out by Luft (98), who studied what he calls "social stimulus deprivation." He brought two strangers together in a room, made them sit across from each other and instructed them "not to talk or communicate in any way." Subsequent interviews revealed the highly stressful nature of this situation. To quote the author:

. . . he has before him the other unique individual with his ongoing, though muted, behavior. At this point, it is postulated, that true interpersonal testing takes place, and only part of this testing may be done consciously. For example, how does the other subject respond to him and to the small non-verbal cues which he sends out? Is there an attempt at understanding his enquiring glance, or is it coldly ignored? Does the other subject display postural cues of tension, indicating some distress at confronting him? Does he grow increasingly comfortable, indicating some kind of acceptance, or will the other treat him as if he were a thing, which did not exist? These and many other kinds of readily discernible behavior appear to take place. . . .

with the development of related pathologies, aside from, indeed in spite of, the motivations or intentions of the communicants.

2.22

In the foregoing, the term "communication" has been used in two ways: as the generic title of our study, and as a loosely defined unit of behavior. Let us now be more precise. We will, of course, continue to refer to the pragmatic aspect of the theory of human communication simply as "communication." For the various units of communication (behavior), we have sought to select terms which are already generally understood. A single communicational unit will be called a *message* or, where there is no possibility of confusion, a *communication*. A series of messages exchanged between persons will be called *interaction*. (For those who crave more precise quantification, we can only say that the sequence we refer to by the term "interaction" is greater than one message but not infinite.) Finally, in Chapters 4-7, we will add *patterns of interaction*, which is a still higher-level unit of human communication.

Further, in regard to even the simplest possible unit, it will be obvious that once we accept all behavior as communication, we will not be dealing with a monophonic message unit, but rather with a fluid and multifaceted compound of many behavioral modes—verbal, tonal, postural, contextual, etc.—all of which qualify the meaning of all the others. The various elements of this compound (considered as a whole) are capable of highly varied and complex permutations, ranging from the congruent to the incongruent and paradoxical. The pragmatic effect of these combinations in interpersonal situations will be our interest herein.

2.23

The impossibility of not communicating is a phenomenon of more than theoretical interest. It is, for instance, part and parcel of the schizophrenic "dilemma." If schizophrenic behavior is observed with etiological considerations in abeyance, it appears that the schizophrenic tries *not to communicate*. But since even nonsense, silence, withdrawal, immobility (postural silence), or any

other form of denial is itself a communication, the schizophrenic is faced with the impossible task of denying that he is communicating and at the same time denying that his denial is a communication. The realization of this basic dilemma in schizophrenia is a key to a good many aspects of schizophrenic communication that would otherwise remain obscure. Since any communication, as we shall see, implies commitment and thereby defines the sender's view of his relationship with the receiver, it can be hypothesized that the schizophrenic behaves as if he would avoid commitment by not communicating. Whether this is his purpose, in the causal sense, is of course impossible of proof; that this is the effect of schizophrenic behavior will be taken up in greater detail in s. 3.2.

2.24

To summarize, a metacommunicational axiom of the pragmatics of communication can be postulated: *one cannot not communicate.*

2.3

The Content and Relationship Levels of Communication

2.31

Another axiom was hinted at in the foregoing when it was suggested that any communication implies a commitment and thereby defines the relationship. This is another way of saying that a communication not only conveys information, but that at the same time it imposes behavior. Following Bateson (132, pp. 179-81), these two operations have come to be known as the "report" and the "command" aspects, respectively, of any communication. Bateson exemplifies these two aspects by means of a physiological analogy: let *A*, *B*, and *C* be a linear chain of neurons. Then the firing of neuron *B* is both a "report" that neuron *A* has fired and a "command" for neuron *C* to fire.

The report aspect of a message conveys information and is, therefore, synonymous in human communication with the content of the message. It may be about anything that is communicable regardless of whether the particular information is true or false, valid, invalid,

or undecidable. The command aspect, on the other hand, refers to what sort of a message it is to be taken as, and, therefore, ultimately to the relationship between the communicants. All such relationship statements are about one or several of the following assertions: "This is how I see myself . . . this is how I see you . . . this is how I see you seeing me . . ." and so forth in theoretically infinite regress. Thus, for instance, the messages "It is important to release the clutch gradually and smoothly" and "Just let the clutch go, it'll ruin the transmission in no time" have approximately the same information content (report aspect), but they obviously define very different relationships. To avoid any misunderstanding about the foregoing, we want to make it clear that relationships are only rarely defined deliberately or with full awareness. In fact, it seems that the more spontaneous and "healthy" a relationship, the more the relationship aspect of communication recedes into the background. Conversely, "sick" relationships are characterized by a constant struggle about the nature of the relationship, with the content aspect of communication becoming less and less important.

2.32

It is quite interesting that before behavioral scientists began to wonder about these aspects of human communication, computer engineers had come across the same problem in their work. It became clear to them that when communicating with an artificial organism, their communications had to have both report and command aspects. For instance, if a computer is to multiply two figures, it must be fed this information (the two figures) *and* information about this information: the command "multiply them."

Now, what is important for our consideration is the relation existing between the content (report) and the relationship (command) aspects of communication. In essence it has already been defined in the preceding paragraph when it was mentioned that a computer needs *information* (data) and *information about this information* (instructions). Clearly, then, the instructions are of a higher logical type than the data; they are *metainformation* since

they are information *about* information, and any confusion between the two would lead to a meaningless result.

2.33

If we now return to human communication, we see that the same relation exists between the report and the command aspects: the former conveys the "data" of the communication, the latter how this communication is to be taken. "This is an order" or "I am only joking" are verbal examples of such communications about communication. The relationship can also be expressed nonverbally by shouting or smiling or in a number of other ways. And the relationship may be clearly understood from the context in which the communication takes place, e.g., between uniformed soldiers, or in a circus ring.

The reader will have noticed that the relationship aspect of a communication, being a communication about a communication, is, of course, identical with the concept of metacommunication elaborated in the first chapter, where it was limited to the conceptual framework (and to the language the communication analyst must employ when communicating about communication. Now it can be seen that not only he but everyone is faced with this problem. The ability to metacommunicate appropriately is not only the *conditio sine qua non* of successful communication, but is intimately linked with the enormous problem of awareness of self and others. This point will be explained in greater detail in s. 3.3. For the moment, and by way of illustration, we merely want to show that messages can be constructed, especially in written communication, which offer highly ambiguous metacommunicational clues. As Cherry (34, p. 120) points out, the sentence "Do you think that one will do?" can have a variety of meanings, according to which word is to be stressed—an indication that written language usually does not supply. Another example would be a sign in a restaurant reading "Customers who think our waiters are rude should see the manager," which, at least in theory, can be understood in two entirely different ways. Ambiguities of this kind are not the only possible complica-

tions arising out of the level structure of all communication; consider, for instance, a notice that reads "Disregard This Sign." As we shall see in the chapter on paradoxical communication, confusions or contaminations between these levels—communication and meta-communication—may lead to impasses identical in structure to those of the famous paradoxes in logic.

2.34

For the time being let us merely summarize the foregoing into another axiom of our tentative calculus: *Every communication has a content and a relationship aspect such that the latter classifies the former and is therefore a metacommunication.*³

2.4

The Punctuation of the Sequence of Events

2.41

The next basic characteristic of communication we wish to explore regards interaction—exchanges of messages—between communicants. To an outside observer, *a series of communications can be viewed as an uninterrupted sequence of interchanges*. However, the participants in the interaction always introduce what, following Whorf (1955), Bateson and Jackson have termed the "punctuation of the sequence of events." They state:

The stimulus-response psychologist typically confines his attention to sequences of interchange so short that it is possible to label one item of input as "stimulus" and another item as "reinforcement" while labelling what the subject does between these two events as "response." Within the short sequence so excised, it is

³ We have chosen, somewhat arbitrarily, to say that the relationship classifies, or subsumes, the content aspect, although it is equally accurate in logical analysis to say that the class is defined by its members and therefore the content aspect can be said to define the relationship aspect. Since our primary interest is not information exchange but the pragmatics of communication, we will use the former approach.

possible to talk about the "psychology" of the subject. In contrast, the sequences of interchange which we are here discussing are very much longer and therefore have the characteristic that every item in the sequence is simultaneously stimulus, response and reinforcement. A given item of A's behavior is a stimulus insofar as it is followed by an item contributed by B and that by another item contributed by A. But insofar as A's item is sandwiched between two items contributed by B, it is a response. Similarly A's item is a reinforcement insofar as it follows an item contributed by B. The ongoing interchanges, then, which we are here discussing, constitute a chain of overlapping triadic links, each of which is comparable to a stimulus-response-reinforcement sequence. We can take any triad of our interchange and see it as a single trial in a stimulus-response learning experiment.

If we look at the conventional learning experiments from this point of view, we observe at once that repeated trials amount to a differentiation of relationship between the two organisms concerned—the experimenter and his subject. The sequence of trials is so punctuated that it is always the experimenter who seems to provide the "stimuli" and the "reinforcements," while the subject provides the "responses." These words are here deliberately put in quotation marks because the role definitions are in fact only created by the willingness of the organisms to accept the system of punctuation. The "reality" of the role definitions is only of the same order as the reality of a bat on a Rorschach card—a more or less over-determined creation of the perceptive process. The rat who said "I have got my experimenter trained. Each time I press the lever he gives me food" was declining to accept the punctuation of the sequence which the experimenter was seeking to impose.

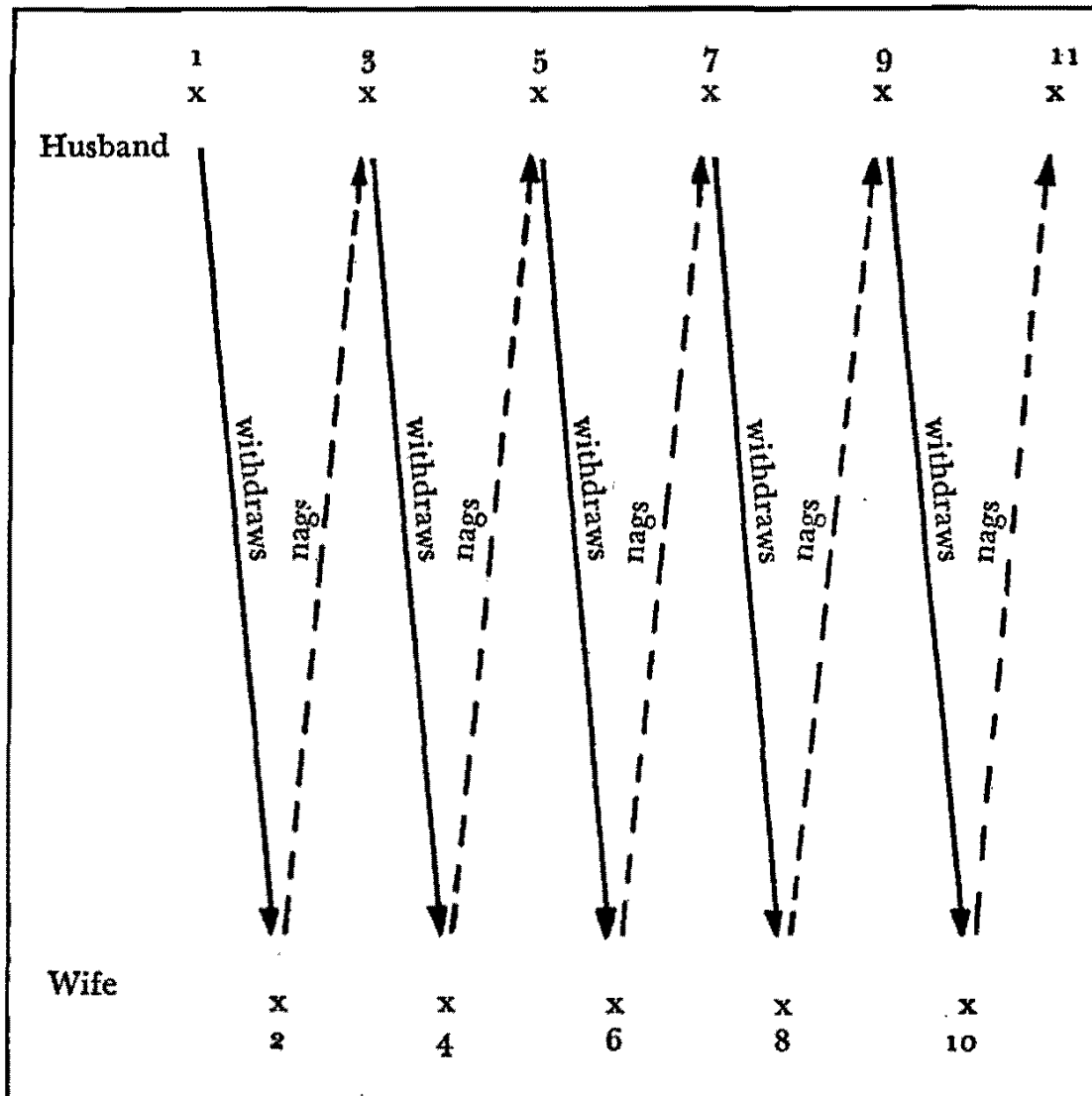
It is still true, however, that in a long sequence of interchange, the organisms concerned—especially if these be people—will in fact punctuate the sequence so that it will appear that one or the other has initiative, dominance, dependency or the like. That is, they will set up between them patterns of interchange (about which they may or may not be in agreement) and these patterns will in fact be rules of contingency regarding the exchange of reinforcement. While rats are too nice to re-label, some psychiatric patients are not, and provide psychological trauma for the therapist! (19, pp. 273-74)

It is not the issue here whether punctuation of communicational sequence is, in general, good or bad, as it should be immediately obvious that punctuation organizes behavioral events and is therefore vital to ongoing interactions. Culturally, we share many conventions of punctuation which, while no more or less accurate than other views of the same events, serve to organize common and important interactional sequences. For example, we call a person in a group behaving in one way the "leader" and another the "follower," although on reflection it is difficult to say which comes first or where one would be without the other.

2.42

Disagreement about how to punctuate the sequence of events is at the root of countless relationship struggles. Suppose a couple have a marital problem to which he contributes passive withdrawal, while her 50 per cent is nagging criticism. In explaining their frustrations, the husband will state that withdrawal is his only *defense against* her nagging, while she will label this explanation a gross and willful distortion of what "really" happens in their marriage: namely, that she is critical of him *because of* his passivity. Stripped of all ephemeral and fortuitous elements, their fights consist in a monotonous exchange of the messages "I withdraw because you nag" and "I nag because you withdraw." This

type of interaction has already been mentioned briefly in s. 1.65. Represented graphically, with an arbitrary beginning point, their interaction looks somewhat like this:



It can be seen that the husband only perceives triads 2-3-4, 4-5-6, 6-7-8, etc., where his behavior (solid arrows) is "merely" a response to her behavior (the broken arrows). With her it is exactly the other way around; she punctuates the sequence of events into the triads 1-2-3, 3-4-5, 5-6-7, etc., and sees herself as only reacting to, but not determining, her husband's behavior. In conjoint psychotherapy with couples one is frequently struck by the

intensity of what in traditional psychotherapy would be referred to as "reality distortion" on the part of both parties. It is often hard to believe that two individuals could have such divergent views on many elements of joint experience. And yet the problem lies primarily in an area already frequently mentioned: their inability to metacommunicate about their respective patterning of their interaction. This interaction is of an oscillatory yes-no-yes-no-yes nature which theoretically can go on ad infinitum and almost invariably is accompanied, as we shall see later, by the typical charges of badness or madness.

International relations, too, are rife with analogous patterns of interaction; take for instance C. E. M. Joad's analysis of arms races:

. . . if, as they maintain, the best way to preserve peace is to prepare war, it is not altogether clear why all nations should regard the armaments of other nations as a menace to peace. However, they do so regard them, and are accordingly stimulated to increase their armaments to overtop the armaments by which they conceive themselves to be threatened. . . . These increased arms being in their turn regarded as a menace by nation A whose allegedly defensive armaments have provoked them, are used by nation A as a pretext for accumulating yet greater armaments wherewith to defend itself against the menace. Yet these greater armaments are in turn interpreted by neighbouring nations as constituting a menace to themselves and so on. . . . (79, p. 69)

Again, mathematics supplies a descriptive analogy: the concept of "infinite, oscillating series." While the term itself was introduced much later, series of this kind were studied in a logical, consistent manner for the first time by the Austrian priest Bernard Bolzano shortly before his death in 1848, when, it would appear, he was deeply involved with the meaning of infinity. His thoughts

appeared posthumously in the form of a small book entitled *The Paradoxes of the Infinite* (30), which became a classic of mathematical literature. In it Bolzano studied various kinds of series (S), of which perhaps the simplest is the following:

$$S = a - a + a - a + a - a + a - a + a - a + a - \dots$$

For our purposes this series may be taken to stand for a communicational sequence of assertions and denials of message *a*. Now, as Bolzano showed, this sequence can be grouped—or, as we would say, punctuated—in several different, but arithmetically correct, ways.⁴ The result is a different limit for the series depending on how one chooses to punctuate the sequence of its elements, a result which consternated many mathematicians, including Leibnitz. Unfortunately, as far as we can see, the solution of the paradox offered eventually by Bolzano is of no help in the analogous communicational dilemma. There, as Bateson (17) suggests, the dilemma arises out of the spurious punctuation of the series, namely, the pretense that it has a beginning, and this is precisely the error of the partners in such a situation.

2.44

Thus we add a third metacommunicational axiom: *The nature of a relationship is contingent upon the punctuation of the communicational sequences between the communicants.*

⁴ The three possible groupings ("punctuations") are:

$$\begin{aligned} S &= (a - a) + (a - a) + (a - a) + (a - a) + \dots \\ &= 0 + 0 + 0 + \dots \\ &= 0 \end{aligned}$$

Another way of grouping the elements of the sequence would be:

$$\begin{aligned} S &= a - (a - a) - (a - a) - (a - a) - (a - a) - \dots \\ &= a - 0 - 0 - 0 - \dots \\ &= a \end{aligned}$$

Still another way would be:

$$S = a - (a - a + a - a + a - a + a - \dots)$$

and since the elements contained in the brackets are nothing but the series itself, it follows that:

$$S = a - S$$

Therefore $2S = a$, and $S = \frac{a}{2}$. (30, pp. 49-50)

2.5

Digital and Analogic Communication

2.51

In the central nervous system the functional units (neurons) receive so-called quantal packages of information through connecting elements (synapses). Upon arrival at the synapses these "packages" produce excitatory or inhibitory postsynaptic potentials that are summed up by the neuron and either cause or inhibit its firing. This specific part of neural activity, consisting in the occurrence or nonoccurrence of its firing, therefore conveys binary digital information. The humoral system, on the other hand, is not based on digitalization of information. This system communicates by releasing discrete quantities of specific substances into the bloodstream. It is further known that the neural and the humoral modes of intraorganismic communication exist not only side by side, but that they complement and are contingent upon each other, often in highly complex ways.

The same two basic modes of communication can be found at work in the field of man-made organisms:⁵ there are computers which utilize the all-or-none principle of vacuum tubes or transistors and are called *digital*, because they are basically calculators working with digits; and there is another class of machines that manipulate discrete, positive magnitudes—the analogues of the data—and hence are called *analogic*. In digital computers both

⁵ Interestingly enough, there is reason to believe that computer engineers arrived at this result quite independently from what the physiologists already knew at the time, a fact which in itself provides a beautiful illustration of von Bertalanffy's (25) postulate that complex systems have their own inherent lawfulness that can be followed throughout the various systemic levels, i.e., the atomic, molecular, cellular, organismic, individual, societal, etc. The story goes that during an interdisciplinary gathering of scientists interested in feedback phenomena (probably one of the Josiah Macy Foundation meetings), the great histologist von Bonin was shown the wiring diagram of a selective reading device and immediately said: "But this is just a diagram of the third layer of the visual cortex. . . ." We cannot vouch for the authenticity of this story, but would hold it with the Italian proverb "se non è vero, è ben trovato" (even if it is not true, it still makes a good story).

data and instructions are processed in the form of numbers so that often, especially in the case of the instructions, there is only an arbitrary correspondence between the particular piece of information and its digital expression. In other words, these numbers are arbitrarily assigned code names which have as little resemblance to actual magnitudes as do the telephone numbers assigned to the subscribers. On the other hand, as we have already seen, the analogy principle is the essence of all analogic computation. Just as in the humoral system of natural organisms the carriers of information are certain substances and their concentration in the bloodstream, in analogue computers data take the form of discrete and, therefore, always positive quantities, e.g., the intensity of electrical currents, the number of revolutions of a wheel, the degree of displacement of components, and the like. A so-called tide machine (an instrument composed of scales, cogs, and levers formerly used to compute the tides for any given time) can be considered a simple analogue computer, and, of course, Ashby's homeostat, mentioned in Chapter 1, is a paradigm of an analogue machine, even though it does not compute anything.

2.52

In human communication, objects—in the widest sense—can be referred to in two entirely different ways. They can either be represented by a likeness, such as a drawing, or they can be referred to by a name. Thus, in the written sentence "The cat has caught a mouse" the nouns could be replaced by pictures; if the sentence were spoken, the actual cat and the mouse could be pointed to. Needless to say, this would be an unusual way of communicating, and normally the written or spoken "name," that is, the word, is used. These two types of communication—the one by a self-explanatory likeness, the other by a word—are, of course, also equivalent to the concepts of the analogic and the digital respectively. Whenever a word is used to *name* something it is obvious that the relation between the name and the thing named is an arbitrarily established one. Words are arbitrary signs that are manipulated according to the logical syntax of language. There is no particular reason why the three letters "c-a-t" should denote a particular

animal. In ultimate analysis it is only a semantic convention of the English language, and outside this convention there exists no other correlation between any word and the thing it stands for, with the possible but insignificant exception of onomatopoeic words. As Bateson and Jackson point out: "There is nothing particularly five-like in the number five; there is nothing particularly table-like in the word 'table'" (19, p. 271).

In analogic communication, on the other hand, there *is* something particularly "thing-like" in what is used to express the thing. Analogic communication can be more readily referred to the thing it stands for. The difference between these two modes of communication may become somewhat clearer if it is realized that no amount of listening to a foreign language on the radio, for example, will yield an understanding of the language, whereas some basic information can fairly easily be derived from watching sign language and from so-called intention movements, even when used by a person of a totally different culture. Analogic communication, we suggest, has its roots in far more archaic periods of evolution and is, therefore, of much more general validity than the relatively recent, and far more abstract, digital mode of verbal communication.

What then is analogic communication? The answer is relatively simple: it is virtually all nonverbal communication. This term, however, is deceptive, because it is often restricted to body movement only, to the behavior known as kinesics. We hold that the term must comprise posture, gesture, facial expression, voice inflection, the sequence, rhythm, and cadence of the words themselves, and any other nonverbal manifestation of which the organism is capable, as well as the communicational clues unfailingly present in any *context* in which an interaction takes place.⁶

Man is the only organism known to use both the analogic and

⁶The paramount communicational significance of context is all too easily overlooked in the analysis of human communication, and yet anyone who brushed his teeth in a busy street rather than in his bathroom might be quickly carted off to a police station or to a lunatic asylum—to give just one example of the pragmatic effects of nonverbal communication.

the digital modes of communication.⁷ The significance of this is still very inadequately understood, but can hardly be overrated. On the one hand there can be no doubt that man communicates digitally. In fact, most, if not all, of his civilized achievements would be unthinkable without his having evolved digital language. This is particularly important for the sharing of information about *objects* and for the time-binding function of the transmission of knowledge. And yet there exists a vast area where we rely almost exclusively on analogic communication, often with very little change from the analogic inheritance handed down to us from our mammalian ancestors. This is the area of *relationship*. Based on Tinbergen (153) and Lorenz (96), as well as his own research, Bateson (8) has shown that vocalizations, intention movements, and mood signs of animals are analogic communications by which they define the nature of their relationships, rather than making denotative statements about objects. Thus, to take one of his examples, when I open the refrigerator and the cat comes, rubs against my legs, and mews, this does not mean "I want milk"—as a human being would express it—but invokes a specific relationship, "Be mother to me," because such behavior is only observed in kittens in relation to adult cats, and never between two grown-up animals. Conversely, pet lovers often are convinced that their animals "understand" their speech. What the animal does understand, needless to say, is certainly not the meaning of the words, but the wealth of analogic communication that goes with speech. Indeed, wherever relationship is the central issue of communication, we find that digital language is almost meaningless. This is not only the case between animals and between man and animal, but in many other contingencies in human life, e.g., courtship, love, succor, combat, and, of course, in all dealings with very young children or severely disturbed mental patients. Children, fools, and animals have always been credited with particular intuition regarding the sincerity or insincerity of human attitudes, for it is easy to profess something verbally, but difficult to carry a lie into the realm of the analogic.

⁷ There is reason to believe that whales and dolphins may also use digital communication, but the research in this area is not yet conclusive.

In short, if we remember that every communication has a content and a relationship aspect, we can expect to find that the two modes of communication not only exist side by side but complement each other in every message. We can further expect to find that the content aspect is likely to be conveyed digitally whereas the relationship aspect will be predominantly analogic in nature.

2.54

In this correspondence lies the pragmatic importance of certain differences between the digital and analogic modes of communication which will now be considered. In order to make these differences clear, we can return to the digital and analogic modes as represented in artificial communication systems.

The performance, accuracy, and versatility of the two types of computers—digital and analogue—are vastly different. The analogues used in analogue computers in lieu of actual magnitudes can never be more than approximations of the real values, and this ever-present source of inaccuracy is further increased during the process of the computer operations themselves. Cogs, gears, and transmissions can never be built to perfection, and even when analogue machines rely entirely on discrete intensities of electrical currents, electrical resistances, rheostats, and the like, these analogues are still subject to virtually uncontrollable fluctuations. A digital machine, on the other hand, could be said to work with perfect precision if space for storing digits were not restricted, thus making it necessary to round off any results having more digits than the machine could hold. Anyone who has used a slide rule (an excellent example of an analogue computer) knows that he can only get an approximate result, while any desk calculator will supply an exact result, as long as the digits required do not exceed the maximum the calculator can handle.

Apart from its perfect precision, the digital computer has the enormous advantage of being not only an arithmetic, but also a *logical*, machine. McCulloch and Pitts (191) have shown that the sixteen truth functions of the logical calculus can be represented by combinations of all-or-none organs, so that, for instance, the

summation of two pulses will represent the logical "and," the mutual exclusiveness of two pulses represents the logical "or," a pulse which inhibits the firing of an element represents negation, etc. Nothing even remotely comparable is possible in analogue computers. Since they operate only with discrete, positive quantities they are unable to represent any negative value, including negation itself, or any of the other truth functions.

Some of the characteristics of computers also apply to human communication: digital message material is of a much higher degree of complexity, versatility, and abstraction than analogic material. Specifically, we find that analogue communication has nothing comparable to the logical syntax of digital language. This means that in analogic language there are no equivalents for such vitally important elements of discourse as "if—then," "either—or," and many others, and that the expression of abstract concepts is as difficult, if not impossible, as in primitive picture writing, where every concept can only be represented by its physical likeness. Furthermore, analogic language shares with analogic computing the lack of the simple negative, i.e., an expression for "not."

To illustrate: there are tears of sorrow and tears of joy, the clenched fist may signal aggression or constraint, a smile may convey sympathy or contempt, reticence can be interpreted as tactfulness or indifference, and we wonder if perhaps all analogic messages have this curiously ambiguous quality, reminiscent of Freud's *Gegensinn der Urworte* (antithetical sense of primal words). Analogic communication has no qualifiers to indicate which of two discrepant meanings is implied, nor any indicators that would permit a distinction between past, present, or future.⁸ These qualifiers

⁸ By now the reader will have discovered for himself how suggestive a similarity there exists between the analogic and the digital modes of communication and the psychoanalytic concepts of *primary* and *secondary processes* respectively. If transposed from the intrapsychic to the interpersonal frame of reference, Freud's description of the id becomes virtually a definition of analogic communication:

The laws of logic—above all, the law of contradiction—do not hold for processes in the id. Contradictory impulses exist side by side without neutralizing each other or drawing apart. . . . There is nothing in the id which can be compared to negation,

and indicators do, of course, exist in digital communication. But what is lacking in digital communication is an adequate vocabulary for the contingencies of relationship.

Man, in his necessity to combine these two languages, either as sender or receiver, must constantly *translate* from the one into the other, and in doing so encounters very curious dilemmas, which will be taken up in greater detail in the chapter on pathological communication (s. 3.5). For in human communication, the difficulty of translation exists both ways. Not only can there be no translation from the digital into the analogic mode without great loss of information (see s. 3.55 on hysterical symptom formation), but the opposite is also extraordinarily difficult: to talk about relationship requires adequate translation from the analogic into the digital mode of communication. Finally we can imagine similar problems when the two modes must coexist, as Haley has noted in his excellent chapter, "Marriage Therapy":

When a man and a woman decide their association should be legalized with a marriage ceremony, they pose themselves a problem which will continue through the marriage: now that they are married are they staying together because they wish to or because they must? (60, p. 119)

In the light of the foregoing, we would say that when to the mostly analogic part of their relationship (courtship behavior) is added a digitalization (the marriage contract) an unambiguous definition of their relationship becomes very problematic.⁹

2.55

To summarize: *Human beings communicate both digitally and analogically. Digital language has a highly complex and powerful*

and we are astonished to find in it an exception to the philosophers' assertion that space and time are necessary forms of our mental acts (49, p. 104; italics ours)

⁹ For the same reasons, it is possible to suggest that divorce would be experienced as something much more definite if the usually dry and uninspiring legal act of obtaining the final decree were implemented by some form of analogic ritual of final separation.

logical syntax but lacks adequate semantics in the field of relationship, while analogic language possesses the semantics but has no adequate syntax for the unambiguous definition of the nature of relationships.

2.6

Symmetrical and Complementary Interaction

2.61

In 1935 Bateson (6) reported on an interactional phenomenon which he observed in the Iatmul tribe in New Guinea and which, in his book *Naven* (10), published a year later, he dealt with in greater detail. He called this phenomenon *schismogenesis* and defined it as *a process of differentiation in the norms of individual behavior resulting from cumulative interaction between individuals*. In 1939 Richardson (125) applied this concept to his analyses of war and foreign politics; since 1952 Bateson and others have demonstrated its usefulness in the field of psychiatric research (Cf. 157, pp. 7-17; also 143). This concept, which, as we can see, has a heuristic value beyond the confines of any one discipline, was elaborated by Bateson in *Naven* as follows:

When our discipline is defined in terms of the reactions of an individual to the reactions of other individuals, it is at once apparent that we must regard the relationship between two individuals as liable to alter from time to time, even without disturbance from outside. We have to consider, not only *A*'s reactions to *B*'s behaviour, but we must go on to consider how these affect *B*'s later behaviour and the effect of this on *A*.

It is at once apparent that many systems of relationship, either between individuals or groups of individuals, contain a tendency towards progressive change. If, for example, one of the patterns of cultural behaviour, considered appropriate in individual

A, is culturally labelled as an assertive pattern, while *B* is expected to reply to this with what is culturally regarded as submission, it is likely that this submission will encourage a further assertion, and that this assertion will demand still further submission. We have thus a potentially progressive state of affairs, and unless other factors are present to restrain the excesses of assertive and submissive behavior, *A* must necessarily become more and more assertive, while *B* will become more and more submissive; and this progressive change will occur whether *A* and *B* are separate individuals or members of complementary groups.

Progressive changes of this sort we may describe as *complementary* schismogenesis. But there is another pattern of relationships between individuals or groups of individuals which equally contains the germs of progressive change. If, for example, we find boasting as the cultural pattern of behaviour in one group, and that the other group replies to this with boasting, a competitive situation may develop in which boasting leads to more boasting, and so on. This type of progressive change we may call *symmetrical* schismogenesis. (10, pp. 176-77)

2.62

The two patterns just described have come to be used without reference to the schismogenetic process and are now usually referred to simply as symmetrical and complementary interaction. They can be described as relationships based on either equality or difference. In the first case the partners tend to mirror each other's behavior, and thus their interaction can be termed symmetrical. Weakness or strength, goodness or badness, are not relevant here, for equality can be maintained in any of these areas. In the second case one partner's behavior complements that of the other, forming a different sort of behavioral Gestalt, and is called complementary. Symmetrical interaction, then, is characterized by equal-

ity and the minimization of difference, while complementary interaction is based on the maximization of difference.

There are two different positions in a complementary relationship. One partner occupies what has been variously described as the superior, primary, or "one-up" position, and the other the corresponding inferior, secondary, or "one-down" position. These terms are quite useful as long as they are not equated with "good" or "bad," "strong" or "weak." A complementary relationship may be set by the social or cultural context (as in the cases of mother and infant, doctor and patient, or teacher and student), or it may be the idiosyncratic relationship style of a particular dyad. In either case, it is important to emphasize the interlocking nature of the relationship, in which dissimilar but fitted behaviors evoke each other. One partner does not impose a complementary relationship on the other, but rather each behaves in a manner which presupposes, while at the same time providing reasons for, the behavior of the other: their definitions of the relationship (s. 2.3) fit.

2.63

A third type of relationship has been suggested—"metacomplementary," in which *A* lets or forces *B* to be in charge of him; by the same reasoning, we could also add "pseudosymmetry," in which *A* lets or forces *B* to be symmetrical. This potentially infinite regress can, however, be avoided by recalling the distinction made earlier (s. 1.4) between the observation of behavioral redundancies and their inferred explanations, in the form of mythologies; that is, we are interested in *how* the pair behave without being distracted by *why* (they believe) they so conduct themselves. If, though, the individuals involved avail themselves of the multiple levels of communication (s. 2.22) in order to express different patterns on different levels, paradoxical results of significant pragmatic importance may arise (s. 5.41; 6.42, ex. 3; 7.5, ex. 2d).

2.64

The potential pathologies (escalation in symmetry and rigidity in complementarity) of these modes of communication will be

dealt with in the next chapter. For the present, we can state simply our last tentative axiom: *All communicational interchanges are either symmetrical or complementary, depending on whether they are based on equality or difference.*

2.7

Summary

Regarding the above axioms in general, some qualifications should be re-emphasized. First, it should be clear that they are put forth tentatively, rather informally defined and certainly more preliminary than exhaustive. Second, they are, among themselves, quite heterogeneous in that they draw from widely ranging observations on communication phenomena. They are unified not by their origins but by their *pragmatic* importance, which in turn rests not so much on their particulars as on their *interpersonal* (rather than monadic) reference. Birdwhistell has even gone so far as to suggest that

an individual does not communicate; he engages in or becomes part of communication. He may move, or make noises . . . but he does not communicate. In a parallel fashion, he may see, he may hear, smell, taste, or feel—but he does not communicate. In other words, he does not originate communication; he participates in it. Communication as a system, then, is not to be understood on a simple model of action and reaction, however complexly stated. As a system, it is to be comprehended on the transactional level. (28, p. 104)

Thus, the impossibility of not communicating makes all two-or-more-person situations *interpersonal*, communicative ones; the relationship aspect of such communication further specifies this same point. The pragmatic, interpersonal importance of the digital and analogic modes lies not only in its hypothesized isomorphism with

content and relationship, but in the inevitable and significant ambiguity which both sender and receiver face in problems of translation from the one mode to the other. The description of problems of punctuation rests precisely on the underlying metamorphosis of the classic action-reaction model. Finally, the symmetry-complementarity paradigm comes perhaps closest to the mathematical concept of *function*, the individuals' positions merely being variables with an infinity of possible values whose meaning is not absolute but rather emerges only in relation to each other.

Chapter 5

A Communicational Approach to the play

“Who’s Afraid of Virginia Woolf?”

“Go ask the poets”—S. Freud, *Civilization and its Discontents*

5.1

Introduction

The general problem of adequately illustrating the theory of interactional systems described in the previous chapter, as well as our choice of a fictitious system rather than actual clinical data (such as in earlier chapters), deserves some special comment. Having described a unit of recurring, ongoing processes with no single important incident or variable but rather redundant patterns over time and over a wide variety of situations, the first difficulty of providing examples becomes one of sheer size. In order to demonstrate exactly what is meant by the various abstractions that define a system—rules, feedback, equifinality, and so forth—an enormous number of messages, their analysis, and their configurations must be available. Transcripts of hours and hours of family interviews, for instance, would be prohibitively bulky and would be biased by

both the therapist's point of view and by the therapeutic context. Unedited "natural history" data would carry the lack of limits to unusable extreme. Selecting and summarizing is not a ready answer either, for this would be biased in such a way as to deny the reader the right to observe this very process of selection. The second major goal, in addition to manageable size, is thus reasonable independence of the data, that is, independence of the authors themselves, in the sense of being publicly accessible.

Edward Albee's unusual and well-known play seems to satisfy both these criteria. The limits of the data presented in the play are fixed by artistic license, though the play is possibly even more real than reality, a "fire in the soggy ashes of naturalism" (145); and all the information is available to the reader. A consequence of this last fact is that many other interpretations can and have been made of this play, and indeed many are possible. Focusing on one interpretation, as here, does not imply disagreement with others. It is simply that our purpose is to illustrate the thesis at hand and not to exhaustively analyze the play as an independent unit. After a synopsis of the line of action, this chapter will follow as closely as possible the major section structure of Chapter 4, with at least the first decimal headings (5.2, .3, and .4) referring to their counterparts in that chapter.

5.11—PLOT SYNOPSIS

This play, which according to one critic depicts "a limbo of domestic cantankerousness" (107, p. 58), has little concrete action. Most of its movement is contained in fast, detailed verbal interchanges. Through these interchanges the communicational complexity of the four actors' interaction is more starkly developed than would perhaps have been possible if the author had relied more on "real" events in the orthodox dramatic sense.

The entire play takes place during the small hours of a Sunday morning in the living room of George and Martha's house on a New England college campus. Martha is the only child of the college president, and her husband, George, is an associate professor in the history department. She is a large, boisterous woman of

fifty-two, looking somewhat younger; he is a thin, graying intellectual of about forty-six. They are childless. According to Martha, she and her father expected George, who came to the college as a young man, to take over the history department and eventually become the next president of the college. George never lived up to this expectation and has remained an associate professor.

As the play opens, George and Martha are returning home from a faculty party held at the home of Martha's father. It is two o'clock in the morning, but, unbeknown to George, Martha has invited a couple they met at the party to join them. These visitors are Nick, a new man in the biology department, about thirty years old, blond and good-looking, and his wife, Honey, twenty-six, a petite, insipid, mousy blonde. As it is later revealed, Nick married Honey because he thought she was going to have a baby, but her condition turned out to be a hysterical pregnancy, which of course disappeared as soon as they were married; and perhaps he was also motivated by thoughts of her father's wealth. Whether for these or other reasons, Nick and Honey maintain, to each other, an extremely overconventional style of communication.

George and Martha have secrets of their own. There is above all their shared fiction that they have a son who is just coming of age, and a rule related to this imaginary child, namely that they must not disclose his "existence" to anybody. There is also a very dark chapter in George's earlier life. It appears that he accidentally fatally shot his mother and that a year later, while receiving driving instructions from his father, he lost control of the car and his father was killed; but the audience is somehow left wondering if this is not simply another fantasy.

Act One is called "Fun and Games" and provides an introduction to the older couple's style of verbal brawling and to their mythical son, as well as to Martha's (obviously stereotyped) seductive attitude toward Nick. It is climaxed by Martha's scathing attack on George's professional failure.

Act Two, "Walpurgisnacht" (Witches' Sabbath), begins with George and Nick alone in the room, almost competing in the revelation of confidences—George talking about the death of his

parents, although this is disguised as the sad life story of a third person, and Nick explaining why he got married. When the women return, Martha begins to dance brazenly with Nick for George's benefit and the first overtly labeled game, "Humiliate the Host," is played. Martha reveals to their guests how George's parents died, whereupon George attacks her physically. He then initiates the next game, "Get the Guests," and relates, to Nick's extreme mortification and Honey's horror, the secret of their shotgun marriage. In the bitter aftermath, Martha and George exchange challenges and vow further battle. The next game becomes "Hump the Hostess" and leads to Martha's open seduction of Nick, whose ability to cooperate, however, turns out to have been impaired by the constant drinking, which has been going on since the early evening.

Act Three, "Exorcism," opens with Martha alone, regretting yet complaining about her would-be infidelity. George has meanwhile prepared the last game ("Bringing Up Baby") and gathers the other three for this final round. He reveals the full story of the myth about their son and then announces to the helplessly enraged Martha that the boy was "killed" in an auto accident. The nature of this exorcism dawns on Nick ("Jesus Christ, I think I understand this" [p. 236¹]). He and Honey leave, and the play ends on an exhausted, ambiguous note that makes it unclear whether George and Martha will go on playing the game of parents bemoaning the death of their only child in the prime of his youth, or whether a complete change of their relationship patterns has now become possible.

5.2

Interaction As a System

The characters in this play, especially George and Martha, can be seen as comprising an interactional system, characterized, *mutatis mutandis*, by many of the properties of general systems. There is no harm in emphasizing once more that such a model is neither

¹ Page references, in brackets, are to the Atheneum edition (r).

literal nor comprehensive; that is, these characters, as those in real ongoing relationships, are not considered in any sense mechanical, automated, or completely defined by their interactional aspects. Indeed, the power of a model as a scientific device rests in this deliberately simplified representation and organization of the subject of discourse (2).

5.21—TIME AND ORDER, ACTION AND REACTION

Gregory Bateson defined social psychology as "the study of the reactions of individuals to the reactions of other individuals," adding, "We have to consider, not only A's reactions to B's behavior, but we must go on to consider how these affect B's later behavior and the effect of this on A" (10, pp. 175-6). This is the underlying principle of the present analysis. George and Martha are interesting individuals, but they will not be abstracted from their social context (which is, primarily, each other) and considered as "types." Rather the unit of analysis will be what goes on, sequentially, between them: Martha as she reacts to George and he to her. These transactions accumulate, over larger time periods, taking on an order that, though abstracted, is still essentially comprised of sequential processes.

5.22—DEFINITION OF THE SYSTEM

An interactional system was defined in s. 4.22 as two or more communicants in the process of, or at the level of, defining the nature of their relationship. As we have tried to explain in the preceding chapters, relationship patterns exist independently from content although, of course, in actual life they are always manifested by and through content. If attention is limited to the content of what people communicate to each other, then indeed there often seems to be hardly any continuity in their interaction—"time always starts afresh and history is always in the year zero." And so it is with Albee's play: for three painful hours the spectator witnesses a kaleidoscopic sequence of ever-changing events. But what is their common denominator? Alcoholism, impotence,

childlessness, latent homosexuality, sadomasochism—all these have been proposed as explanations of what is taking place between these two couples during the small hours of a Sunday morning. In his Stockholm production, Ingmar Bergman stressed “the christological reference in the sacrifice of the son by the father—the son who was a gift of the father to the mother, of heaven to earth, of God to mankind” (109). As long as the *content* of communication is the criterion, all these viewpoints, contradictory as some of them are, appear justified to a certain degree.

But Albee himself supplies an altogether different viewpoint. Act One is called “Fun and Games”: games of relationships are being played throughout the play, and rules are constantly invoked, followed, and broken. They are terrifying games, devoid of all playful characteristics, and their rules are their own best explanation. Neither the games nor the rules answer the question *why*? As Schimel, too, points out:

It is appropriate that the first act is entitled “Fun and Games,” a study of repetitious, although destructive, *patterns of behavior between people*. Albee graphically represents the “how” of games and leaves the “why” up to the audience and critics. (141, p. 99; italics ours)

It little matters then if, for instance, George is really an academic failure and for the reasons Martha describes, or if Nick is really the Scientist of the Future who threatens history and historians. Consider, for instance, the latter—George’s frequent references [e.g., pp. 36–40, 65–68] to history and the biology of the future (eugenics, conformity). This may be seen as a personal, rather peevish preoccupation, as he terms it; as social commentary; even as an allegory of the struggle of traditional Western man (George) against the wave of the future (Nick), with the “Earth Mother” (as Martha calls herself [p. 189]) as the prize; or as all of these and more. But seen in terms of George and Nick’s *relationship*, this topic is another “bean bag” (as George later describes the mythical

son [p. 98]), that is, a toy, often a missile—the medium through which their game is manifested. In this sense, George's digressions on history and biology can be seen as provocations disguised as defense and, thus, as a very interesting communicational phenomenon involving disqualification, denial of communication (with the effect of progressive involvement), and a punctuation that leads to a self-fulfilling prophecy in which Nick really does take George's wife.

Similarly, it appears that George and Martha are so caught up in their relationship struggle that they do not take the content of their insults personally (in fact Martha will not permit Nick to call George the same things she calls him nor to interfere with their game [e.g., p. 190, p. 204]); they seem to respect each other *in the system*.

5.23—SYSTEMS AND SUBSYSTEMS

The main focus of the play, and of this commentary, is on the dyad George-and-Martha. They are, however, an "open system," and the concept of hierarchical structure is appropriate here. Each of them forms a subdyad with Nick and, to a far lesser extent, with Honey. Nick-and-Honey are of course another dyadic system which moreover stands in a notable relation to George-and-Martha by virtue of the formers' starkly contrasting complementarity. George, Martha, and Nick comprise a triangle of shifting dyads.² The four as a whole are the total visible system of the drama, although the structure is not limited to the cast present but also involves, and on occasion invokes, the unseen son, Martha's father, and the campus milieu. Present purposes will not permit exhaustive classification and analysis of all the possibilities, and we are left with what Lawrence Durrell (41) called "Workpoints"—a virtual infinity of revolutions and new views as other facets of the structure are elaborated; for example, Nick and Honey's peculiar complementarity; Martha's aggressive boldness fitting Nick's narcissism;

² In which any two are a unit against the third, as when Martha and Nick dance or otherwise mock George [e.g., pp. 130-6], or George and Martha team up against Nick [e.g., pp. 196-7].

George and Nick's tense rapprochement;³ Martha and George's competition for her father; and so forth.

As a final comment, it is instructive that Albee works almost exclusively with smaller units, at most shifting dyads into a triangle or (in the men versus women aspect and perhaps spuriously) two against two. The use of three or four units at once would probably be too complicated.

5.3

The Properties of an Open System

The general characteristics of systems can be illustrated by restating them in terms of George and Martha's system, especially with contrast, for clarity, with individual approaches.

5.31—WHOLENESS

Ideally, we would describe the gestalt, the emergent quality of this cast of characters. Their relationships are both something more and something other than what the individuals bring into them. That which is George or Martha, individually, does not explain what is compounded between them, nor how. To break this whole into individual personality traits or structures is essentially to separate them from each other, to deny that their behaviors have special meaning in the context of this interaction—that in fact the pattern of the interaction perpetuates these. Phrased in other terms, wholeness is a description of the overlapping triadic links of stimulus-response-reinforcement described by Bateson and Jackson (19) and discussed in s. 2.41. So instead of focusing on the motivations of the individuals involved, it is possible, at another level, to describe the system *as workable*, with any emphasis on individuals directed to the appropriateness of their behavior to

³ Which gives an interactional meaning to the title "Walpurgisnacht," in which George shows Nick the orgy [p. 115] just as Mephistopheles showed Faust.

this system. All the conclusions of Chapter 1—the Black Box approach, consciousness versus unconsciousness, present versus past, circularity, and the relativity of "normal" and "abnormal"—should be kept in mind as corollaries of the principle of system wholeness.

The *unilateral* view of this dyad is taken almost unanimously by journalistic reviewers, who seem to "favor" George as the victim in the situation. But the only difference between George's and Martha's recriminations is that he accuses her of strength while she accuses him of weakness. If the reviewers acknowledge his part in the battle at all, George is seen as resorting to his tactics after hard provocation. In our view, this is a system of mutual provocation that neither party can stop. It is, however, enormously difficult to describe such circularity with the balance it justifies and requires, mostly because of the lack of an adequate vocabulary to describe mutually causal relations,⁴ and also because one must start somewhere, and wherever the circle is broken analytically, a starting point is implied.

Because Martha's offenses are obvious and unmistakable and because she so easily fits the stereotype of an emasculating harridan, George's actions tend to be more emphasized here. This is, of course, not simply to shift the blame, for blame is not the issue; it is rather that Martha and George both make her contribution obvious: it is, in fact, their shared punctuation that she is the active and he the passive one (though they put different values on activity and passivity, with George, for instance, seeing himself as restrained and Martha calling this weakness). But this is a tactic of their game; what should be seen as basic is that they are playing the game together.

This emphasis on circularity will also neglect more than cursory mention of their individual redeeming qualities, although in fact both are quite bright and perceptive, both show compassion on occasion, and both seem aware, at different points, of the fearful destructiveness of their game and apparently want to stop it.

⁴Maruyama has created the term "multilateral mutual simultaneous causal relations" (100).

5.32—FEEDBACK

The feedback processes in this perhaps simplified system correspond precisely to symmetry (positive, deviation-amplifying feedback) and complementarity (negative, stabilizing feedback). The "everything you can do I can do better" format of symmetrical competition inexorably leads to more of the same, with increment piling on augmentation in runaway proportions. Conversely, a switch to complementarity in this system—acceptance, compliance, laughter, sometimes even inaction—usually brings closure and at least temporary surcease of struggle.

There are, however, exceptions to this general pattern. As the tempo increases in both acrimony and cycle size (from brief, almost playful banter to more significant and larger patterns such as "Humiliate the Host"), similarly larger deviation-corrections are required to counteract this tendency, and, as Martha and George demonstrate, their skills in conciliation contrast sadly with those for combat. Metacommunication, a possible stabilizer, proves to be subject to the same rule of symmetry (s. 5.43), and, instead of stopping the conflagration, further ignites it. There are even more problems when complementarity in the service of symmetry (s. 5.41) leads to paradox and further precludes resolution.

In s. 5.42, the son myth will be considered as a strictly controlled paradigm of their system, with built-in homeostatic mechanisms of a different sort.

5.33—EQUIFINALITY

Considering a system as something developed over a period of time, achieving a certain state, or changing from one state to another, there emerge two very different ways to account for the present state. One common approach is to observe or, as is more common and necessary in human study, to infer the initial conditions (etiology, past causes, history) that presumably led to the present conditions. In an interactional system such as George and Martha's, these initial conditions may be either shared experiences in courtship or early marriage or, even earlier, they may be

individual personality patterns fixed in the early life of each or both. Of the former, a causal role could be assigned, for example, to Martha's accidental knockout of George, about which she says, "I think it's colored our whole life. Really I do. It's an excuse, anyway" [p. 57]; or, less superficially, to the circumstances surrounding this event including the failure of George to materialize as "heir-apparent" to the father's presidency; or to Martha's loss of innocence and/or alcoholism (from "real ladylike little drinkies" to "rubbing alcohol" [p. 24]) that George has long endured; or other such problems dating from the early history of their marriage. Of the individual "initial conditions," the possible explanations are even more varied.⁵ George could be seen as a latent homosexual who despises Martha, using and subtly encouraging her affair with the beautiful young man (and, presumably, others) for his own vicarious satisfaction. Or, Martha and George with the fantasy son or Nick form a classic Oedipal situation, in which not only does Nick attempt to sleep with the mother and find himself impotent, unable to break the taboo, but also the maturing son is killed by the father in exactly the same manner in which George as a boy reportedly killed his own father [compare pp. 95-96 and p. 231]; further, his mock killing of Martha with the toy shotgun [p. 57] duplicates the manner in which he is said to have shot his own mother [p. 94]. These are only suggestions of possible directions of analysis, in all of which the interaction is seen as determined by previous, often individual, conditions which thus would make the best explanation of that interaction.

Several comments have been made earlier (s. 1.2; 1.63; 3.64) about the nature and use of anamnestic data, and a trend toward a more complex conceptualization than one-to-one relationships between past and present has been commented on in the previous chapter (s. 4.33). So it will suffice here, as a critique of the above-described historical approaches, to note again that in this case, as in many—perhaps most—others in human study, the past is not available

⁵ But they are also clearly *summative*, with no explicit explanation of how the other fits into the situation.

except as reported in the present and therefore is not pure content but has a relationship aspect as well. Occurring in an actual interaction in present time, the past-as-reported can also be material for the present game. Truth, selection, and distortion are less important for the understanding of present interaction than how the material is used and what kind of relationship is defined. The view proposed here aims to explore the extent to which system parameters—the rules and limitations observed in the ongoing interaction—can account for both perpetuation and change in the system; that is the extent to which a lawfulness that does not depend on the past can be offered as an explanation of the system.⁶

5.4

An Ongoing Interactional System

At this point, in order to illustrate what is meant by present interaction, a sketch of the rules and tactics of George and Martha's interactional game, as we see it, should be given; then some of the specific aspects of ongoing relationships can be considered.

5.4¹

Their game can be described as *symmetrical escalation* (s. 3.61) with each keeping up with the other or trying to outdo the other, depending on whose punctuation one accepts. This struggle is established at the very beginning when George and Martha run through several quick symmetrical escalations, almost as if practicing, "merely . . . exercising," as George claims [p. 33]. The content is entirely different in each case, but their structure is virtually identical and momentary stability is reached by joint laughter. For instance, at one point Martha tells her husband, "You make me puke!" George considers this with facetious detachment:

⁶ This issue is not, at this stage of knowledge, a dichotomous one, where a choice must be made between total dependence or total independence of initial conditions. It is rather the simpler one of examining in some detail the power of the reciprocal behavioral effects of a communication system such as the family, and questioning—no matter how they started—whether they can stop.

That wasn't a very nice thing to say, Martha.

Martha: That wasn't *what*?

George: . . . a very nice thing to say. [p. 13]

Martha persists less elegantly:

I like your anger. I think that's what I like about you most . . . your anger. You're such a . . . such a simp! You don't even have the . . . the what? . . .

George: . . . guts? . . .

Martha: Phrasemaker! (Pause) [pp. 13-14]

Then they both laugh—at their teamwork, perhaps—and closure has been reached. Laughter seems to signal acceptance and so has a homeostatic, stabilizing effect. But it is by now apparent how pervasive is their symmetry, for even the slightest directive by one precipitates further struggle, with the other immediately retaliating in such a way as to define his equality. Thus Martha tells George to put more ice in her drink, and George, while complying, likens her to a cocker spaniel always chewing ice cubes with her "big teeth," and they are off again:

Martha: THEY'RE MY BIG TEETH!

George: Some of them . . . some of them.

Martha: I've got more teeth than you've got.

George: Two more.

Martha: Well, two more's a lot more. [p. 14]

And George, quickly switching to a known vulnerability:

I suppose it is. I suppose it's pretty remarkable . . . considering how old you are.

Martha: YOU CUT THAT OUT! (Pause) You're not so young yourself.

George: (With boyish pleasure . . . a chant): I'm six years younger than you are. . . . I always have been and I always will be.

Martha: (Glumly): Well . . . you're going bald.

George: So are you. (Pause . . . they both laugh) Hello, honey.

Martha: Hello. C'mon over here and give your Mommy a big sloppy kiss. [pp. 14-15]

And another escalation starts. George sarcastically refuses to kiss her:

Well, dear, if I kissed you I'd get all excited . . . I'd get beside myself, and I'd take you, by force, right here on the living room rug [. . .]

Martha: You pig!

George: (Haughtily): Oink! Oink!

Martha: Ha, ha, ha HA! Make me another drink . . . lover. [pp. 15-16]

The subject now switches to her drinking, the escalation becomes bitter and leads into a power struggle over who is to open the door for the guests who have meanwhile arrived and keep ringing the bell.

Note here that just as neither will take an initiative or command from the other, so neither does anything *but* command or control. Martha does not say, "You can give me some more ice," much less "May I please have . . . ?" but "Hey, put some more ice in my drink, will you?" [p. 14]; similarly she orders him to kiss her and to open the door. Nor is she simply rude and ill-mannered, for not to act so is to put herself at a considerable disadvantage, as George shows later in the play with a well-executed maneuver before their guests, after Martha has openly ridiculed him:

George: (With a great effort controls himself . . . then, as if she had said nothing more than "George, dear." . . .): Yes, Martha? Can I get you something?

Martha: (Amused at his game): Well . . . uh . . . sure, you can light my cigarette, if you're of a mind to.

George: (Considers, then moves off): No . . . there are limits, I mean, man can put up with only so much

without he descends a rung or two on the old evolutionary ladder . . . (Now a quick aside to Nick) . . . which is up your line . . . (Then back to Martha) . . . sinks, Martha, and it's a funny ladder . . . you can't reverse yourself . . . start back up once you're descending. (Martha blows him an arrogant kiss) Now . . . I'll hold your hand when it's dark and you're afraid of the bogey man, and I'll tote your gin bottles out after midnight, so no one'll see . . . but I will not light your cigarette. And that, as they say, is that. (Brief silence)

Martha: (Under her breath): Jesus! [pp. 50-1]

Similarly, if George is polite or otherwise accepts the one-down position, Martha either calls him spineless or, with some justification, suspects a trap.

Part of a game is its *tactics*; though George's and Martha's styles differ greatly, each is highly consistent and, what is most important, their respective tactics interlock neatly. Martha is crass, overtly insulting, and very directly, almost physically, aggressive. Her language is coarse, her insults seldom eloquent but always straight. Even her most pain-producing thrust ("Humiliate the Host") amounts to a simple exposé.

George, on the other hand, adroitly sets traps, using passivity, indirectness, and civilized restraint as weapons. While Martha insults him along customary lines (with vulgar epithets, or belaboring his professional failure), he invokes subtler values, insulting her articulately and with control, but more often making certain that her behavior in insulting him does not go unnoticed. By quietly framing it, he uses her behavior against her as if with a mirror, delicately turning it back on her—as above, "That wasn't a very nice thing to say, Martha," or, with clearer instigation, when he mimics the simpering Honey:

Hee, hee, hee, hee.

Martha: (Swinging on George): Look, muckmouth . . . you cut that out!

George: (Innocence and hurt): Martha! (To Honey and Nick) Martha's a devil with language; she really is. [p. 21]

It would have been quite effective, perhaps, if Martha had said nothing and let George's rudeness show instead. But she does not use his very tactic, as he must know she will not, and he takes her neatly. Clearly, the behavior of each is predicated on that of the other, with Martha's insults turned into barbs that make her howl the louder.⁷ Thus they fight at entirely different levels, so closure or resolution is effectively prevented: *the tactics themselves serve not only to implement but to perpetuate the game.*

There is in this state of affairs some inherent instability. Martha may, and sometimes does, intensify her attacks beyond manageable limits. George may then switch to her level, as he does in the extreme case by bodily assault after her revelation of his apparent accidental parricides in "Humiliate the Host":

George: (On her): I'LL KILL YOU! (Grabs her by the throat. They struggle)
 Nick: HEY! (Comes between them)
 Honey: (Wildly): VIOLENCE! VIOLENCE! (George, Martha, and Nick struggle . . . yells, etc.)
 Martha: [persisting with her aggravation]: IT HAPPENED! TO ME! TO ME!
 George: YOU SATANIC BITCH!
 Nick: STOP THAT! STOP THAT!
 Honey: VIOLENCE! VIOLENCE! (The other three struggle. George's hands are on Martha's throat. Nick grabs him, tears him from Martha, throws him on the floor. George, on the floor; Nick over him; Martha, to one side, her hand on her throat) [pp. 137-8]

⁷ The formulation "sadomasochistic symbiosis" may spring to mind here, but there are two inadequacies in this view: first, the circularity of their pattern makes it difficult and perhaps arbitrary to decide which role to assign which partner. Even more, such a label is a speculation on *why*, but it is not definitively descriptive; it does not even hint *how* the dyad operates, because it is of course a summative formulation.

Still, he cannot win at that level and must then redouble his response in his own style, as he indicates in the lull that follows this attack:

All right . . . all right . . . very quiet now
. . . we will all be . . . very quiet.

Martha: (Softly, with a slow shaking of her head): Murderer. Mur . . . der . . . er.

Nick: (Softly to Martha): O.K. now . . . that's enough.
(A brief silence. They all move around a little, self-consciously, like wrestlers flexing after a fall)

George: (Composure seemingly recovered, but there is a great nervous intensity): Well! That's one game. What shall we do now, hunh? (Martha and Nick laugh nervously) Oh come on . . . let's think of something else. We've played Humiliate the Host . . . we've gone through that one . . . what shall we do now?

Nick: Aw . . . look . . .

George: AW LOOK! (Whines it) AWWW . . . loooooook.
(Alert) I mean, come on! We must know other games, college-type types like us . . . that can't be the . . . limit of our vocabulary, can it? [pp. 138-9]

And he immediately suggests the variation that will occupy them until the final denouement. It is "Hump the Hostess," a game of *coalitions* that requires Nick's participation. Now, the addition of a third party to an already tangled interaction, with consequent shifting subdyads, considerably increases the complexity of the game. Previously the use of the guests was only quasi-coalitional, in which they served as backboards, so to speak, for George and Martha's shots.⁸ In this last-but-one round, however, the third party (Nick) is more directly involved. Since the latter

⁸ Ogden Nash has contributed to the formalization of this method in his poem "Don't Wait, Hit Me Now!" which goes, in part:

Here is the formula, in which the presence of a third person is the only essential extra ingredient; . . .

does not rise to the game at first, George lays the groundwork with another game, "Get the Guests," after which Nick is ready:

- Nick: (To George, as he moves toward the hall): You're going to regret this.
- George: Probably. I regret everything.
- Nick: I mean, I'm going to make you regret this.
- George: (Softly): No doubt. Acute embarrassment, eh?
- Nick: I'll play the charades like you've got 'em set up . . . I'll play in your language . . . I'll be what you say I am.
- George: You are already . . . you just don't know it. [pp. 149-50]

Yet the most remarkable aspect of the ensuing events is their conformity to George and Martha's basic rules and respective tactics. For each, again, is out to get the other, Martha by the flagrant insult of unconcealed adultery, George by in fact setting this up and then, again, thrusting her own behavior upon her. Thus, instead of entering with her into another symmetrical escalation, he suddenly not only agrees (complementarily) with her threat of betraying him with Nick, but even suggests that she go ahead and sets up the situation accordingly. This is no simple outrage, and is not painless to George [p. 173]. Martha is prepared for a new escalation, but not for this kind of communication (which will be considered in greater detail in s. 7.3 under the heading "Prescribing the Symptom"), which leaves her defenseless and,

Suppose you think your Gregory danced too often with Mrs. Limbworthy at the club, you don't say to him directly, "Gregory, I'll smack you down if you don't lay off that platinum-plated hussy,"

No, you wait till a friend drops in and then with a glance at Gregory say to her, "Isn't it funny what fools middle-aged men can make of themselves over anything blonde and slithery, do you understand how anybody sober and in their right mind could look twice at that Limbworthy job, but then of course darling, Gregory wasn't altogether in his right mind last night, was he?"

This is indeed more excruciating to Gregory than Shakespearian excursions and alarums,

Because there is no defense against caroms. . . .

Because the hit direct doesn't compare with the ricochet in deadly unanswerability. (110, pp. 99-101)

as Albee puts it, "oddly furious" [p. 168]. In the face of her threat, George quietly announces that he is going to read a book:

Martha: You're gonna do *what*?

George: (quietly, distinctly): I am going to read a book. Read. Read. Read? You've heard of it? (Picks up a book)

Martha: Whaddya mean you're gonna read? What's the matter with you? [p. 168]

Now Martha is faced with the alternatives of stopping or continuing in order to see how seriously George means what he says. She takes the second alternative and begins to kiss Nick. George is immersed in his reading:

Martha: You know what I'm doing, George?

George: No, Martha . . . what are you doing?

Martha: I'm entertaining. I'm entertaining one of the guests. I'm necking with one of the guests. [p. 170]

But George does not rise to the challenge. Martha has used up the challenges that might ordinarily call George's reactions into play. She tries once more:

Martha: . . . I said I was necking with one of the guests.

George: Good . . . good. You go right on.

Martha: (Pauses . . . not knowing quite what to do): Good?

George: Yes, good . . . good for you.

Martha: (Her eyes narrowing, her voice becoming hard): Oh, I see what you're up to, you lousy little. . . .

George: I'm up to page a hundred and . . . [p. 171]

Uncertain what to do, Martha sends Nick into the kitchen, then turns to George again:

Martha: Now you listen to me . . .

George: I'd rather read, Martha, if you don't mind . . .

Martha: (Her anger has her close to tears, her frustration

to fury): Well, I do mind. Now, you pay attention to me! You come off this kick you're on, or I swear to God I'll do it. I swear to God I'll follow that guy into the kitchen, and then I'll take him upstairs, and . . .

George: (Swinging around to her again . . . loud . . . loathing): SO WHAT, MARTHA? [p. 173]

Similarly, he turns on Nick:

Nick: You don't . . . you don't even . . .

George: Care? You're quite right . . . I couldn't care less. So, you just take this bag of laundry here, throw her over your shoulder, and . . .

Nick: You're disgusting.

George: (Incredulous): Because *you're* going to hump Martha, *I'm* disgusting? (He breaks down in ridiculing laughter) [p. 172]

Later, it is not even necessary for George to point this out to Martha, as she comments on her own behavior:

I disgust me. I pass my life in crummy, totally pointless infidelities . . . (Laughs ruefully) *would-be* infidelities. Hump the Hostess? That's a laugh. [p. 189]

5.411

George and Martha's competitive game is not, as it may seem on the surface or in specific instances, simply one of open conflict in which the object is solely to destroy the other. Rather, in its more general aspects, it appears to be collaborative conflict, or conflictive collaboration: there may be some "upper limit" to their escalation, and there are shared rules, as already implied, on how the game is played. These rules qualify the basic rule of symmetry and give winning (or losing) its value within the game; without them, winning and losing have no meaning.

Without excessive formalization, it can be said that the con-

straint on their symmetry (which in itself, would logically lead to murder—directly and literally, not metaphorically as in the play) is that they must be not only effective but witty and daring. Paradigmatic is the following perfectly symmetrical exchange of insults:

George: Monstre!
 Martha: Cochon!
 George: Bête!
 Martha: Canaille!
 George: Putain! [p. 101]

There is a certain off-beat stylishness to their articulate though vicious deportment, which makes Nick and especially Honey the blander by comparison. Neither of the latter makes a suitable sub-partner in the game; Martha's disappointment with Nick is not only sexual but that he is passive and rather unimaginative, and George, who tries Nick out as a sparring partner at times, seems also to find him poor competition:

George: (Toying with him): I asked you how you liked that for a declension: Good; better; best; bested. Hm? Well?
 Nick: (With some distaste): I really don't know what to say.
 George: (Feigned incredulousness): You really don't know what to say?
 Nick: (Snapping it out): All right . . . what do you want me to say? Do you want me to say it's funny, so you can contradict me and say it's sad? or do you want me to say it's sad so you can turn around and say no, it's funny. You can play that damn little game any way you want to, you know!
 George: (Feigned awe): Very good! Very good!
 Nick: (Even angrier than before): And when my wife comes back [to the living room], I think we'll just. . . . [pp. 32-3]

Besides their colorfulness, then, George and Martha find, even demand in each other a certain strength, an ability to take anything into the game without flinching. In the last act, George teams with Martha to ridicule Nick, even when the material of the joke is his cuckoldry:

Martha: (To Nick): Ach! You just stay where you are.
Make my hubby a drink.

Nick: I don't think I will.

George: No, Martha, no; that would be too much; he's your houseboy, baby, not mine.

Nick: I'm nobody's houseboy.

George and Martha: . . . (Sing) I'm nobody's houseboy now . . . (Both laugh).

Nick: Vicious . . .

George: (Finishing it for him): . . . children. Hunh? That right? Vicious children, with their oh-so-sad games, hopscotching their way through life, etcetera, etcetera. Is that it?

Nick: Something like it.

George: Screw, baby.

Martha: Him can't. Him too fulla booze.

George: Weally? (Handing the snapdragons to Nick) Here; dump these in some gin. [pp. 196-7]

This callous daring is also seen in their "brinkmanship," in which outdoing or "getting" the other requires less and less restraint and more and more imagination. For instance, Martha is delighted at a particularly terrifying riposte of George's: she is ridiculing George to Nick and Honey when he returns to the scene, his hands behind his back, at first in sight only of Honey; Martha continues with the story of her knocking out George:

And it was an *accident* . . . a real, goddamn accident! (George takes from behind his back a short-barreled shotgun, and calmly aims it at the back of Martha's head. Honey screams . . . rises. Nick

risers, and, simultaneously, Martha turns her head to face George, George pulls the trigger)

George: POW!!!

(Pop! From the barrel of the gun blossoms a large red and yellow Chinese parasol. Honey screams again, this time less, and mostly from relief and confusion) You're dead! Pow! You're dead!

Nick: (Laughing): Good Lord.

(Honey is beside herself. Martha laughs too . . . almost breaks down, her great laugh booming. George joins in the general laughter and confusion. It dies, eventually)

Honey: Oh! My goodness!

Martha: (Joyously): Where'd you get that, you bastard?
[. . .]

George: (A trifle abstracted): Oh, I've had it awhile. Did you like that?

Martha: (Giggling): You bastard. [pp. 57-8]

Martha's joy and giggling may be in part sheer relief, but there is also an almost sensual delight in the game well played, a delight which they both share:

George: (Leaning over Martha): You liked that, did you?

Martha: Yeah . . . that was pretty good. (Softer) C'mon . . . give me a kiss.

The result, however, cannot be closure, for just as their rivalry has sexual aspects, their sexual behavior is also rivalry, and when Martha persists with direct advances, George demures; she will not be dissuaded, and he eventually gains a "Pyrrhic victory" [p. 59] in refusing her and commenting, for their guests to hear, on the impropriety of her behavior.

Thus their shared style represents a further restriction, another regularity in their game. Further, it is apparent that there is some mutual confirmation of their selves in the excitement of the risk.

However, there is also extreme rigidity that prevents either from more than briefly appreciating or building on this confirmation.

5.42—THE SON

The imaginary son is a unique topic deserving of separate treatment. Many reviewers, while enthusiastic about the play in general, have reservations about this issue. Malcolm Muggeridge feels "the play falls to pieces in the third act, when the lamentable business of the imaginary child is developed" (107, p. 58); and Howard Taubman protests that

Mr. Albee would have us believe that for 21 years his older couple have nurtured a fiction that they have a son, that his imaginary existence is a secret that violently binds and sunders them and that George's pronouncing him dead may be a turning point. This part of the story does not ring true, and its falsity impairs the credibility of his central characters. (152)

We do not agree, first, on the basis of psychiatric evidence. The credibility of the existence of the fiction is not precluded by its delusional proportions, nor by the fact that it must be shared between them. Since the classic *folie à deux*, other shared, reality-distorting experiences have been described. Ferreira has referred to the "family myth" as

a series of fairly well-integrated beliefs shared by all family members, concerning each other and their mutual position in the family life, beliefs that go unchallenged by everyone involved in spite of the reality distortions which they may conspicuously imply. (42, p. 457)

What is noteworthy in this formulation is that (1) the issue of literal belief is not central and (2) the function of the deception is relational.

Considering the first point, Ferreira comments, "The individual family member may know, and often does, that much of the image

is false and represents no more than a sort of official party line" (42, p. 458). Nowhere does Albee suggest that George and Martha "really" believe they have a son. When they speak *about* this, their usage is clearly impersonal, referring not to a person but to the myth itself. When the fiction of the son is first mentioned, early in the play, George speaks of "the bit . . . the bit about the kid," [p. 18]. Later he even puns about their double-reference system:

George: . . . you brought it out into the open. When is he coming home, Martha?

Martha: I said never mind. I'm sorry I brought it up.

George: Him up . . . not it. You brought *him* up. Well, more or less. When's the little bugger going to appear, hunh? I mean, isn't tomorrow meant to be his birthday, or something?

Martha: [. . .] I DON'T WANT TO TALK ABOUT IT!

George: I bet you don't. (To Honey and Nick) Martha does not want to talk about it . . . him. Martha is sorry she brought it up . . . him. [p. 70]

This distinction between the "son" and the "son-game" is so consistently maintained, even to Martha's immediate reaction to George's announcement of the death—"You can't decide that for yourself" [p. 232]—that it is not possible to assume that they literally believe they have a son.

If this is so, then why do they play the game of pretending to have a son? Again, *what for* is a better question than *why*. As Ferreira describes it:

The family myth represents nodal, resting points in the relationship. It ascribes roles and prescribes behavior which, in turn, will strengthen and consolidate those roles. Parenthetically we may observe that, in its content, it represents a group departure from reality, a departure that we could call "pathology." But at the same time it constitutes *by its very existence*, a frag-

ment of life, a piece of reality that faces, and thus shapes [any] children born into it and the outsiders that brush by. (42, p. 462; italics ours)

This last point is most important. While the son is imaginary, their interaction about him is not, and the nature of this interaction, then, becomes the fruitful question.

The primary requirement of interaction about the son is a coalition between George and Martha; they *must* be together on this fiction in order to maintain it for, unlike a real child who, once procreated, exists, here they must constantly unite to create their child. And, changing the focus slightly, in this one area they *can* get together, collaborating without competition. The story is so "far-out" and private that they can perhaps afford to be together in it precisely because it is not real. In any case, they can and do fight about him just as about everything else, but there is a built-in limit to their game of symmetrical escalation in the necessity to share this fiction. *Their child-myth is a homeostatic mechanism.* In what appears to be a central area of their life they have a stable symmetrical coalition. And thus Martha, in her dreamlike recitation of the child's life, describes him in what could be metaphor:

. . . and as he grew . . . oh! so wise! . . . he walked evenly between us . . . (She spreads her hands) . . . a hand out to each of us for what we could offer [. . .] and these hands, still, to hold us off a bit, for mutual protection [. . .] to protect himself . . . and us. [pp. 221-2]

There is every reason to assume that a real child, had they had one, would have faced the same task. Although we do not actually observe it, because the play centers on the misuse of the myth, we can conjecture the following, with Ferreira:

Seemingly, the family myth is called into play whenever certain tensions reach predetermined thresholds among family members and in some way, real or fantasied, threaten to disrupt ongoing relationships. Then, the family myth functions like the thermostat

that is kicked into action by the "temperature" in the family. Like any other homeostatic mechanism, the myth prevents the family system from damaging, perhaps destroying, itself. It has therefore the qualities of any "safety valve," that is, a *survival* value. . . . It tends to maintain and sometimes even to increase the level of organization in the family by establishing patterns that perpetuate themselves with the circularity and self-correction characteristic of any homeostatic mechanism. (42, p. 462)

Real children, too, can be both salve and excuse for a marriage; so, as Fry pointed out (s. 4.442), can symptomatic behavior serve the same function.

But the play does not concern this use of the myth, but rather, ostensibly, the process of destruction of the myth. As noted, anything regarding the son's very existence is not fair ammunition in their warfare. To act otherwise, even in the heat of the battle, is considered truly wrong:

Martha: George's biggest problem about the little . . . ha, ha, ha, HA! . . . about our son, about our great big son, is that deep down in the private-most pit of his gut, he's not completely sure it's his own kid.

George: (Deeply serious): My God, you're a wicked woman.

Martha: And I've told you a million times, baby . . . I wouldn't conceive with anyone but you . . . you know that, baby.

George: A deeply wicked person.

Honey: (Deep in drunken grief): My, my, my, my. Oh, my.

Nick: I'm not sure that this is a subject for . . .

George: Martha's lying. I want you to know that, right now. Martha's lying. (Martha laughs) There are very few things in this world that I *am* sure of . . . national boundaries, the level of the ocean, political allegiances, practical morality . . . none

of these would I stake my stick on any more . . .
 but the one thing in this whole sinking world that
 I am sure of is my partnership, my chromosomo-
 logical partnership in the . . . creation of our
 . . . blond-eyed, blue-haired [*sic*] . . . son. [pp.
 71-2]

Yet it is George who, as far as can be determined, makes the move which sets into motion the system change. In the first moments of the play, apparently caught between Martha's ordering him to answer the door and the guests waiting outside, he concedes but, typically, adds a retort of his own to keep even: he tells her not to mention the son [p. 18]. They have, as George explicitly states later, a rule not to mention him to others [p. 237], so George's comment may seem unnecessary but also unimportant. However, there is a higher "rule"—their entire game—that neither will be permitted to determine the behavior of the other; so any order must be disqualified or disobeyed. In this sense, it little matters who made the first wrong move, for the predictable result of this confusion of the boundaries of the game is Martha's defiance and incorporation of this material into their symmetrical competition. Thus,

George: Just don't start in on the bit about the kid, that's all.

Martha: What do you take me for?

George: Much too much.

Martha: (Really angered): Yeah? Well, I'll start in on the kid if I want to.

George: Just leave the kid out of this.

Martha: (Threatening): *He's mine as much as he is yours.* I'll talk about him if I want to.

George: I'd advise against it, Martha.

Martha: Well, good for you. (Knock) C'mon in. Get over there and open the door!

George: You've been advised.

Martha: Yeah . . . sure. Get over there! [pp. 18-19; italics ours]

As soon as the occasion permits, Martha tells Honey about their son and his birthday.⁹ Now their homeostatic mechanism is mere fuel on the fire, and George will ultimately destroy the son altogether, invoking an implicit right of either ("I have the right, Martha. We never spoke of it; that's all. I could kill him any time I wanted to." [p. 236])

What we witness on the stage, then, is the beginning of a symmetrical runaway that eventually leads to the overthrow of a long-lasting relationship pattern. More than anything else, the play is the case history of a systemic *change*, a change in the rules of a relationship game that comes, we feel, from a small but perhaps inevitable confounding of those rules. The play does not define a new pattern, the new rules; it merely depicts the sequence of states through which the old pattern proceeds to its own destruction. (In s. 7.2 the *general* aspects of systemic change from within and without a system will be considered.) What might happen next is not clear:

George: (Long silence): It will be better.

Martha: (Long silence): I don't . . . know.

George: It will be . . . maybe.

Martha: I'm . . . not . . . sure.

George: No.

Martha: Just . . . us?

⁹ It is interesting that later, after the "death," she pleads amnesia for this:

George: You broke our rule, baby. You mentioned him . . . you mentioned him to someone else.

Martha: (Tearfully): I did *not*. I never did.

George: Yes, you did.

Martha: Who? WHO?

Honey: (Crying): To me. You mentioned him to me.

Martha: (Crying): I FORGET! Sometimes . . . sometimes when it's night, when it's late, and . . . and everybody else is . . . talking . . . I forget and I . . . want to mention him . . . but I . . . HOLD ON . . . I hold on . . . but I've wanted to . . . so often . . . [pp. 236-7]

Neither she nor George sees the conflict of relationship rules which led to this.

George: Yes.

Martha: I don't suppose, maybe, we could . . .

George: No, Martha.

Martha: Yes. No. [pp. 240-1]

Excluding the unassessable fact that Nick and Honey are now involved by their knowledge, Ferreira makes a cogent summary and prediction in terms of the family myth:

. . . a family myth . . . subserves important homeostatic functions in the relationship. . . . [P]erhaps better than anywhere else, these functions of the family myth come to the fore in Edward Albee's well-known play, "Who's Afraid of Virginia Woolf?", where a family myth of psychotic proportions dominates the whole action. Throughout the play, a husband and wife talk, fight, and cry about their absent son. In an orgy of vilifications, they dispute every incident in their son's life, the color of his eyes, his birth, upbringing, etc. However, we learn much later, the son is fictitious, an agreement between the two, a tale, a myth—but a myth that they both cultivated. At the height of the play, the husband, seething with anger, announces that the son is dead. With this gesture, of course, he "kills" the myth. However, their relationship goes on, seemingly undisturbed by the announcement, and there transpires no notion of impending change or dissolution. In fact, nothing had changed. *For the husband had destroyed the myth of a living son only to initiate the myth of a dead one.* Obviously, the family myth had only evolved in its content which became, perhaps, more elaborate, more "psychotic"; its function, we surmise, remained intact. And so did the relationship. (43)

On the other hand, perhaps the death of the son is a recalibration, a step-functional change to a new level of operation. We cannot know.

5.43—METACOMMUNICATION BETWEEN GEORGE AND MARTHA

Metacommunication, as defined in s. 1.5, describes our discourse on George and Martha's rules of communication. But insofar as George and Martha talk or attempt to talk *about* their game, they metacommunicate within the play itself. This is of interest for a number of reasons, for instance regarding the issue of George and Martha's apparent "game-consciousness." That is, their numerous references to, naming of, and citing rules for games may seem to make them an unusual couple whose pattern of interaction is more basically an obsessive-compulsive preoccupation with playing and labeling bizarre and cruel games—really, as George suggests, "Vicious children, with their oh-so-sad games, hopscotching their way through life, etcetera, etcetera" [p. 197]. But this implies both that their game behavior is fully deliberate (or governed by different metarules) and that therefore perhaps the principles they demonstrate, being essentially only the idiosyncratic *content* of their game, cannot be applied to other couples, especially real ones. The nature of their metacommunication bears directly on this question, for it will be seen that *even their communication about their communication is subject to the rules of their game.*

In two striking instances of some length [pp. 150-9, 206-9], George and Martha discuss their interaction explicitly. The first of these metacommunicative exchanges indicates how differently each views the interaction and how, when these differences are revealed, mutual charges of madness or badness are immediately made (s. 3.4). Martha has objected to "Get the Guests," which she apparently sees as out of order or not in the rules:

George: (Barely contained anger now): You can sit there in that chair of yours, you can sit there with the gin running out of your mouth, and you can humiliate me, you can tear me apart . . . ALL NIGHT . . . and that's perfectly all right . . . that's O.K. . . .

Martha: YOU CAN STAND IT!

George: I CANNOT STAND IT!

- Martha: YOU CAN STAND IT!! YOU MARRIED ME
FOR IT!! (A silence)
- George: (Quietly): That is a desperately sick lie.
- Martha: DON'T YOU KNOW IT, EVEN YET?
- George: (Shaking his head): Oh . . . Martha.
- Martha: My arm has gotten tired whipping you.
- George: (Stares at her in disbelief): You're mad.
- Martha: For twenty-three years!
- George: You're deluded . . . Martha, you're deluded.
- Martha: IT'S NOT WHAT I'VE WANTED!
- George: I thought at least you were . . . on to yourself.
I didn't know. I . . . didn't know. [pp. 152-3]

This is an unusually clear instance of pathology in the punctuation of the sequence of events, in which George sees himself as justifiably retaliating for Martha's attacks, and Martha sees herself almost as a prostitute hired to "whip" him; each sees himself as responding to the other but never also as a stimulus to the other's actions. They do not see the full nature of their game, its true circularity. These discrepant views become material for further symmetrical escalation. Continuing the above episode:

- George: I thought at least you were . . . on to yourself.
I didn't know. I . . . didn't know.
- Martha: (Anger taking over): I'm on to myself.
- George: (As if she were some sort of bug): No . . . no
. . . you're . . . sick.
- Martha: (Rises—screams): I'LL SHOW YOU WHO'S
SICK! [p. 153]

The competition over who is sick, wrong, or misunderstood continues to a by-now familiar ending, in which they demonstrate their inability to "come together" by the very way in which they handle the issue of their inability to come together:

- George: Once a month, Martha! I've gotten used to it
. . . once a month and we get misunderstood
Martha, the good-hearted girl underneath the

barnacles, the little Miss that the touch of kindness'd bring to bloom again. And I've believed it more times than I want to remember, because I don't want to think I'm that much of a sucker. I don't believe you . . . I just don't believe you. There is no moment . . . there is no moment any more when we could . . . come together.

Martha: (Armed again): Well, maybe you're right, baby. You can't come together with nothing, and you're nothing! SNAP! It went snap tonight at Daddy's party. (Dripping contempt, but there is fury and loss under it) I sat there at Daddy's party, and I watched you . . . I watched you sitting there, and I watched the younger men around you, the men who were going to go somewhere. And I sat there and I watched you, and *you weren't there!* And it snapped! It finally snapped! And I'm going to howl it out, and I'm not going to give a damn what I do, and I'm going to make the damned biggest explosion you ever heard.

George: (Very pointedly): You try it and I'll beat you at your own game.

Martha: (Hopefully): Is that a threat, George? Hunh?

George: That's a threat, Martha.

Martha: (Fake-spits at him): You're going to get it, baby.

George: Be careful, Martha . . . I'll rip you to pieces.

Martha: You aren't man enough . . . you haven't got the guts.

George: Total war?

Martha: Total. (Silence. They both seem relieved . . . elated.) [pp. 157-9]

Again George has quietly challenged Martha, which is not to say that he starts this round any more than any other; there is no real beginning to these rounds. She counterattacks frontally, and he tops this with a dare that she cannot refuse. So it becomes, as we

have frequently pointed out, a new round of the same old game, with the stakes pushed even higher, leaving them relieved, even elated, but none the wiser or different. For there is nothing to distinguish their metacommunication from their ordinary communication; a comment, a plea, an ultimatum *about* their game is no exception to the rules of the game and therefore cannot be accepted or, in a sense, even heard by the other. In the end, when Martha, pleading and pathetic, takes a completely one-down position and repeatedly begs George to stop, the result is inexorably the same:

Martha: (Tenderly; moves to touch him): Please, George, no more games; I . . .

George: (Slapping her moving hand with vehemence): Don't you touch me! You keep your paws clean for the undergraduates!

Martha: (A cry of alarm, but faint)

George: (Grabbing her hair, pulling her head back): Now, you listen to me, Martha; you have had quite an evening . . . quite a night for yourself, and you can't just cut it off whenever you've got enough blood in your mouth. We are going on, and I'm going to have at you, and it's going to make your performance tonight look like an Easter pageant. Now I want you to get yourself a little alert. (Slaps her lightly with his free hand) I want a little life in you, baby. (Again)

Martha: (Struggling): Stop it!

George: (Again): Pull yourself together! (Again) I want you on your feet and slugging, sweetheart, because I'm going to knock you around, and I want you up for it. (Again; he pulls away, releases her; she rises)

Martha: All right, George. What do you want, George?

George: An equal battle, baby; that's all.

Martha: You'll get it!

George: I want you mad.

Martha: I'M MAD!!
 George: Get madder!
 Martha: DON'T WORRY ABOUT IT!
 George: Good for you, girl; now, we're going to play this one to the death.
 Martha: Yours!
 George: You'd be surprised. Now, here come the tots; you be ready for this.
 Martha: (She paces, actually looks a bit like a fighter): I'm ready for you. [pp. 208-9]

Nick and Honey re-enter and the Exorcism begins.

They are thus playing what will be described in detail as the "game without end" (s. 7.2), in which the self-reflexiveness of the rules leads to a paradox precluding resolution within the system.

5.44—LIMITATION IN COMMUNICATION

It was noted in s. 4.42 that every exchange of messages in a communicational sequence narrows the number of possible next moves. The interlocking nature of George and Martha's game, their shared myth, and the pervasiveness of their symmetry have illustrated the stabilized limitation which has been called relationship rules.

Examples of limitation in a new relationship are provided by a number of exchanges between George and Nick. The latter, by his initial behavior and his own protests, does not want to become involved with George or Martha or their quarrel. Still, as in the sample above (s. 5.411 [pp. 32-3]), he is increasingly drawn in even while staying out. At the beginning of Act Two, the by-now wary Nick encounters the same sort of escalation from small talk to intense anger again:

George: [. . .] It gets pretty bouncy around here sometimes.
 Nick: (Coolly): Yes . . . I'm sure.
 George: Well, you saw an example of it.

- Nick: I try not to . . .
- George: Get involved. Um? Isn't that right?
- Nick: Yes . . . that's right.
- George: I'd imagine not.
- Nick: I find it . . . embarrassing.
- George: (Sarcastic): Oh, you do, hunh?
- Nick: Yes. Really. Quite.
- George: (Mimicking him): Yes. Really. Quite. (Then aloud, but to himself) IT'S DISGUSTING!
- Nick: Now look! I didn't have anything . . .
- George: DISGUSTING! (Quietly, but with great intensity) Do you think I like having that . . . whatever-it-is . . . ridiculing me, tearing me down, in front of . . . (Waves his hand in a gesture of contemptuous dismissal) YOU? Do you think I *care* for it?
- Nick: (Cold—unfriendly): Well, no . . . I don't imagine you care for it at all.
- George: Oh, you don't imagine it, hunh?
- Nick: (Antagonistic): No . . . I don't. I don't imagine you do!
- George: (Withering): Your sympathy disarms me . . . your . . . your compassion makes me weep! Large, salty, unscientific tears!
- Nick: (With great disdain): I just don't see why you feel you have to subject *other* people to it.
- George: *I?*
- Nick: If you and your . . . wife . . . want to go at each other, like a couple of . . .
- George: *I!* Why *I* want to!
- Nick: . . . animals, I don't see why you don't do it when there aren't any . . .
- George: (Laughing through his anger): Why, you smug, self-righteous little . . .
- Nick: (A genuine threat): CAN . . . IT . . . MIS-TER! (Silence) Just . . . watch it! [pp. 90–2]

In this sequence, George's sarcastic attack on Nick's lack of involvement pushes Nick further into disdainful aloofness. But this apparently infuriates George, who, although perhaps seeking sympathy, finishes by insulting Nick until the latter threatens him. On Nick's side, the attempt not to communicate leads to intense involvement, while George's effort to convince Nick of his punctuation of his and Martha's game ends with his demonstrating how infuriating he (George) can be. A pattern for the future is clearly set.

5.45—SUMMARY

It should by now be clear that description of even a fairly simple, artificial family system requires a considerably bulky elaboration, for the variations in content on a few relationship rules are innumerable and often highly detailed. (Reminiscent of this problem is Freud's interpretation of the dream of Irma [50], in which a half-page dream grows into eight pages of interpretation.) The following is a very general summary of George and Martha's interactional system.

5.45¹

A system is said to be stable along certain of its variables if those variables remain within defined limits, and this is true of George and Martha's dyadic system. "Stability" may seem the least appropriate term to describe their indoor commando games, but the issue rests on the variables intended. Their conversations are mercurial, noisy, shocking; restraint and social graces are quickly left behind, as it seems that anything goes. Indeed it would be extremely difficult at any point to guess what will happen next. It would, however, be fairly easy to describe *how* it will happen between George and Martha. For the variables that here define stability are those of relationship, not content, and in terms of their relationship pattern the couple demonstrate an extremely narrow range of behavior.¹⁰

¹⁰ We would even suggest, on the basis of clinical observation and some experimental evidence (61), that pathogenic families generally demonstrate *more constrained* patterns of interaction than do normogenic families. This is in marked contrast to the traditional sociological view of disturbed families as

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This range of behavior is the calibration, the "setting," of their system. The symmetry of their behavior defines the quality and a highly sensitive "lower limit" of this range, that is, nonsymmetrical behavior is rarely and only briefly seen. The "upper limit," as already indicated, is marked by their particular style, some negative feedback in complementarity, and the myth of the son, which, in requiring both of them, sets a limit to how much they can attack each other and enforces a reasonably stable symmetry—until, of course, the distinction between son-rhym and other behavior breaks down, and this area is no longer sacrosanct nor homeostatic. Even within the range of symmetrical behaviors, they are limited: their symmetry is almost exclusively that of the potlatch,¹¹ featuring destruction rather than accumulation or accomplishment.

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With the escalation that leads to the destruction of the son, the system is dramatically ended for us at what may be a recalibration, a step-function, in George and Martha's system. They have escalated almost without limitation until their very limitations were destroyed. Unless the son-myth is continued in the manner Ferreira suggests, a new order of interaction is required; both George and Martha openly express their fear and insecurity, mixed with hope, about the outcome.

chaotic and disorganized; but again the difference resides in the level of analysis and definition of variables. Extreme rigidity of interfamily relationships can appear as—and perhaps even account for—chaos in the family-society interface.

¹¹ A ritual of certain northwestern Indian tribes, in which the chiefs compete in the *destruction* of possessions, symmetrically burning their material goods (2r).